

Canvas Quick-Start Guide

Product Requirements Document: Net New Build

v2 — revised to an optional, behavior-based guide (not an auto-advancing tutorial), with data-driven research findings incorporated.

Build name: Canvas Quick-Start Guide

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1. Problem

New signups may struggle to translate their intended task into an initial, useful canvas action, even though Excalidraw already provides some first-use orientation through its existing welcome screen. This is a working hypothesis, not an established finding: we do not yet have Excalidraw's internal funnel data confirming how many users this affects or which specific step they get stuck on.

It remains the highest-leverage place to focus, per the Head of Product's brief: it happens in the very first moments of a user's first visit, sits upstream of every other product metric, and is directly observable in session data, even though that data hasn't been shared with us yet.

Evidence status

The Head of Product brief identifies first-session activation as the priority. Our working hypothesis is that some new users struggle to translate their intended task into an initial canvas action despite existing interface hints. We have not yet established the prevalence of this problem or whether the main barrier is choosing what to create, using a tool, understanding saving, or encountering a technical failure. The Quick-Start guide will target whichever barrier is supported by baseline analytics and observed first-use sessions, once we have them.

Supporting Context

- Activation rate, the percentage of new signups who complete and save a first drawing within their first session, is the Head of Product's stated topline KPI (full definition quoted in section 2d).
- Correction from initial draft: Excalidraw already ships a welcome screen with quick actions and interface hints, and "Generate anything (AI)" is listed as in-progress on the public roadmap, also aimed at helping users get started. Quick-Start is not filling a total void; it needs to be pitched as extending help past that first screen and adapting to what a user does next, not as introducing orientation where none exists.
- Slide templates are a documented, shipped feature, not a published activation experiment. They're useful as a product precedent showing Excalidraw already reduces blank-surface hesitation elsewhere, not as proof that the same mechanism will work here.
- Public sources (Semrush, Similarweb, Excalidraw's own year-in-review posts) confirm substantial historical traffic and user growth, but contain no verifiable activation, retention, or account-creation percentages. Any target we set in this PRD is a placeholder pending real internal analytics, not a benchmarked figure.

Failure Modes to Validate

Before committing to a specific interaction, we want to confirm which of these is actually happening, since each implies a different fix. These are proposed research categories, not measured findings.

Possible failure mode	Evidence to collect	Implication for the feature
Knows what to make, can't operate the tool	Observed unsuccessful actions, paired with the user's own explanation	Improve the specific interaction or its discoverability; a guide may not be the fix
Understands the tools, doesn't know how to start	User can operate tools but struggles to create an initial representation of their idea	Supports a lightweight, optional Quick-Start that reduces the effort of beginning
Drew something, unsure if it saved	User-created content exists; user expresses uncertainty about persistence	Focus on save-state clarity rather than first-action guidance
App or save operation failed	Loading, persistence, or auth errors in session logs	Fix the reliability issue; don't mistake a bug for confusion
Came to view or discuss someone else's work	Entry into an existing shared or read-only scene	Don't count the absence of a new drawing as failed use for this population

1a. Opportunity

If new users clear the specific step where they're actually getting stuck, activation improves without any change to acquisition, which is already working through word-of-mouth and embed links.

Addressable impact should be sized against the specific failure step, not total users:

Additional activated users = Eligible new signups × Measured absolute activation improvement at the specific step this feature addresses

Illustrative only, not Excalidraw data: if 1,000 new signups include 200 who abandon at the exact step this feature targets, recovering half of those failures would mean 100 additional activations, roughly a 10-point improvement, assuming nothing else changes. The real numbers depend on data we don't have yet.

Key question for the Head of Product: What percentage of new signups currently fail at the specific step this feature could realistically improve? Without that, our improvement target is a placeholder, not a forecast.

One claim we're walking back from the original draft: not every visitor who leaves without drawing represents lost value. Some arrive via shared links or embeds specifically to view or discuss someone else's work, not to create something new; treating their exit as a failed activation overstates the opportunity.

1b. Users & Needs

Excalidraw's free editor doesn't require an account, so "new signup," "first-time visitor," and "new collaborator" are different populations with different needs. We're separating them explicitly rather than treating one intervention as right for all three.

Population	What we measure separately
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New account holder	The Head of Product's signup-based activation KPI; note known prior editor use where available
First-seen anonymous visitor	First-visit creation behavior, labeled by browser/device when identity is unavailable
New collaborator on an existing scene	Contribution behavior appropriate to their permissions, not assumed creation of a brand-new drawing

Feature eligibility (whether Quick-Start appears at all) is broader than the KPI population: it's meant for anyone genuinely new to Excalidraw, not just people who created an account. Guest users who draw regularly without ever signing up already have a real relationship with the product, so they should never see a guide meant for first-timers.

We determine genuine first use on-device rather than by account status alone. Before showing Quick-Start, we check whether the browser already holds Excalidraw data, a past drawing, saved library items, or a flag from having seen the guide before. If either signal is present, the user is treated as not-new and the guide is skipped, regardless of whether they've ever created an account. This keeps Quick-Start out of the way for exactly the population most likely to be annoyed by it, experienced guest users, while still reaching first-time visitors who never sign up.

Key User Needs

- As a first-time user, I need to get from my idea to an initial mark on the canvas without being forced through steps I don't need.
- As a user who already knows the tools, I need the guide to get out of my way immediately rather than assuming I need help.
- As a returning guest who's never created an account, I need the guide to recognize I'm not new from my existing drawings or library items, so I'm not shown a first-timer experience I don't need.
- As a new collaborator entering someone else's canvas, I need my situation handled separately from a brand-new signup, since I'm not starting a drawing from scratch.

2. Proposed Solution

The Canvas Quick-Start Guide is an optional, non-blocking prompt that offers the next relevant piece of help based on what a user actually does on the canvas, not a fixed, auto-advancing tour. A first-time user sees a small, dismissible prompt (for example: "Making your first diagram? Turn a process into a simple drawing. Help me get started · Keep drawing"). If they opt in, the system watches their next action and offers one relevant nudge at a time; if they ignore it entirely and start drawing on their own, the guide gets out of the way and never blocks or delays that.

How it responds to behavior (MVP, rule-based, no ML required)

Observed behavior	Proposed response
Opted in, hasn't created anything yet	Offer a small editable starter or highlight the shape tool, not a full template marketplace
Created shapes, hasn't added labels	One relevant hint: "Double-click a shape to name this step"

Labeled shapes, hasn't connected them	Show how to connect two steps with an arrow; skip this once they do it themselves
Indicates they're finished	Confirm where the drawing is stored and surface the save action or confirmed save status

A missing arrow or a pause is a signal to offer something, not proof of confusion, and it should never trigger an intrusive popup or change someone's drawing automatically.

2a. Value Proposition

First-time Excalidraw visitors who aren't sure how to begin use the Canvas Quick-Start Guide, an optional, behavior-based prompt, to get one relevant nudge toward their first useful action. Unlike a fixed onboarding sequence, it adapts to what the user actually does and disappears entirely for anyone who doesn't need it, protecting the speed and simplicity current users specifically credit for keeping them on the product.

2b. Top 3 MVP Value Props

The Vitamin (must-have baseline): A new user who wants help can get one relevant, specific suggestion instead of generic instructions or nothing at all.

The Painkiller (solves the core pain): Users who don't know how to start no longer stall indefinitely on a blank canvas, without anyone being forced through steps they don't need.

The Steroid (the magic moment): A user who opts in goes from an empty canvas to a labeled, connected, saved diagram, with the guide adapting in real time and quietly disappearing the moment they don't need it anymore.

2c. Goals & Non-Goals

Goals

- Reduce first-session abandonment for new signups who want help getting started, without slowing down anyone who doesn't.
- Increase first-session activation rate as defined by the Head of Product.
- Identify, before building the full feature, which specific step in the funnel is actually losing users.
- Preserve the immediate, ungated access to the canvas that current users specifically cite as a reason they stay.
- Show the guide only to users who are genuinely new to Excalidraw, whether or not they've created an account, and never to experienced guest users.
- Give every user an explicit, visible way to end the guide at any point, since forcing someone through it before they can back out works against the goal of reducing friction.

Non-Goals

- A mandatory or auto-advancing walkthrough that blocks, sequences, or delays a user's own actions (explicitly rejected; this is what we're building instead of).
- A comprehensive tutorial covering every Excalidraw feature; this targets one funnel step at a time.
- Treating inactivity or a missed action alone as proof of confusion, without a corroborating observed session.
- Personalized or role-based guidance paths; out of scope for this version.

2d. Success Metrics

Client KPI Definition (verbatim, from the Head of Product brief)

“Activation rate: the percentage of new signups who complete and save their first drawing within their first session. We track this from the moment someone lands on a blank canvas to the moment they've created and saved something, no matter how rough. A session resets after a meaningful gap, so someone who opens the app, gets distracted, and comes back an hour later starts a fresh attempt at activation rather than getting credit for an old one.”

Resolving the session-reset ambiguity

The brief mixes “within their first session” with later attempts counting fresh. We're keeping three concepts separate rather than collapsing them:

- User-level first-session activation: did this signup succeed during their original first session?
- Attempt-level completion: did this particular session end in a completed, saved drawing?
- Later activation: did someone who failed initially succeed in a separately defined follow-up window?

The Head of Product should confirm which of these is the official reporting metric before we lock in a target. We will not silently count a later success as a first-session success.

Defining "saved" without adding a task

“Saved” needs to specify which surface, the free editor's local browser storage or the Plus cloud workspace, and what counts as a successful persistence outcome, not merely a save-button click. If Quick-Start inserts a starter, an untouched, unedited starter (or its automatic save) does not count as a completed first drawing.

Revised scorecard

This replaces the earlier draft's tutorial-completion metric, which no longer applies now that this isn't a forced sequence.

Metric	Definition	Why it matters
Primary: first-session activation	% of the agreed new-signup cohort completing and saving a drawing under the confirmed definition	The actual business objective
Diagnostic: first user-authored action	% creating or intentionally editing canvas content in the first session	Distinguishes real work from just clicking a tool
Diagnostic: pre-creation abandonment	% whose session ends with zero user-authored content	Tests whether this is even the problem Quick-Start addresses
Friction protection	Time and number of prerequisite interactions before drawing, for both guided and unguided users	Confirms Quick-Start isn't adding the friction we're trying to remove
Reliability protection	Canvas-ready time and persistence failure rate	Prevents a bug from being mistaken for a comprehension problem
Follow-through	% of the cohort returning to create or edit within days 1–7	Checks whether the first-session win actually sticks

Quick-Start exposure and opt-in rate are tracked as diagnostics, not success targets. A user who ignores it and succeeds anyway is not a failure.

Working hypothesis

A non-blocking Quick-Start guide will increase first-session activation by reducing the effort required to begin a useful drawing, without increasing prerequisite interactions or time-to-first-draw for users who don't need it. We'll evaluate it against the current experience using the agreed signup cohort and activation definition. Feature usage alone will not constitute success.

3. Requirements

User Journey 1: First-time user landing on a blank canvas

Context: This targets the funnel step the Head of Product's brief flags as highest-leverage. Every requirement below is written so the guide can be ignored entirely at zero cost to the user.

Sub-journey: Determining who is actually new

- **[P0]** System checks the device/browser for existing Excalidraw data, a past drawing or saved library items, before deciding whether to show Quick-Start.
- **[P0]** System checks the device/browser for a flag indicating the guide has been shown before.
- **[P0]** If either signal is present, the user is treated as not-new and Quick-Start is skipped entirely, regardless of account status.
- **[P1]** Eligibility logic applies the same way whether or not the user has an account, so a guest who draws regularly is never shown a first-timer experience.

Sub-journey: Immediate, ungated access

- **[P0]** User can begin drawing immediately without accepting, dismissing, or completing any part of Quick-Start.
- **[P0]** User sees a small, dismissible prompt on landing, not a blocking modal.
- **[P1]** User who ignores the prompt entirely sees it disappear on their first canvas interaction, without needing to close it manually.

Sub-journey: Receiving behavior-based guidance (opted in)

- **[P0]** User who opts in receives one relevant hint at a time, based on their most recent action, not a fixed sequence.
- **[P0]** User sees a hint disappear permanently once they've completed that action themselves, without repeating it.
- **[P0]** Every step displays an explicit, visible control to end the guide entirely, not only an implicit dismiss like clicking elsewhere; a user should never have to guess how to back out.
- **[P1]** User can dismiss any individual hint without dismissing the whole guide.
- **[P2]** User can manually reopen guidance later from a help menu if they dismissed it early.

Sub-journey: Save-state clarity

- **[P0]** User who indicates they're finished (or pauses after creating content) sees clear confirmation of whether and where their drawing is saved.
- **[P0]** System distinguishes a genuine user-authored save from an untouched starter's automatic save.

Sub-journey: Measurement & Experimentation

- **[P0]** System records feature eligibility, experiment assignment, exposure, opt-in, first user-authored canvas action, and persistence outcome, using identical event definitions for control and treatment groups.

- **[P0]** System distinguishes local user actions from system-inserted starter content, imported content, and remote collaborator changes, so none of those silently inflate activation.
- **[P0]** Analytics collection excludes drawing text, images, and full scene contents; only the minimal event metadata needed to evaluate the hypothesis is collected.
- **[P0]** Experiment compares the existing experience (control) against Quick-Start (treatment) across all assigned eligible users, including those who ignore the guide, not just those who accept it.
- **[P1]** System measures subsequent creation or editing activity for cohorts that have completed the agreed follow-up window.

User Journey 2: First-time collaborator joining a shared canvas

Context: Because the free editor needs no account, a new collaborator is not necessarily a first-time Excalidraw user, and a viewer isn't necessarily a failed activation. For this release, we're scoping collaborators separately rather than assuming they need the same intervention.

Sub-journey: Entering a shared canvas for the first time

- **[P1]** System tracks new-collaborator entry into an existing scene as a distinct population from new signups, not folded into the same activation number.
- **[P2]** User entering a read-only or view-focused scene is not counted as a failed activation by default.
- **[P2]** Quick-Start for collaborators (if warranted by future data) is scoped as a separate, later initiative, not part of this MVP.

4. Appendix

- Open question: what exact threshold defines “complete and save a first drawing” for activation purposes, and which surface (free editor local storage vs. Plus cloud) counts? This PRD does not redefine it unilaterally.
- Open question: what percentage of new signups currently fail at the specific step Quick-Start targets? Needed before setting a real improvement target.
- Open question: which of the three session-reset interpretations (user-level, attempt-level, later activation) is the Head of Product's official reporting metric?
- Assumption flagged: all numeric targets in this document (the +10 point figure, the 200-of-1,000 illustration) are placeholders pending real baseline data, not measured findings.
- Assumption flagged: technical effort and timeline for this build have not been validated against the actual codebase; estimates are team judgment pending a spike.
- Before running a live experiment, agree on the minimum worthwhile improvement, required sample size, and acceptable performance regressions; don't treat a classroom or recruited-tester demo as production-scale proof.
- Related reference: Excalidraw+ public roadmap and changelog, reviewed for thematic direction; slide templates and the in-progress “Generate anything (AI)” roadmap item are the closest existing precedents.
- Public MAU and traffic figures (company disclosures through Jan 2025; third-party Semrush/Similarweb estimates through Aug 2026) confirm scale and general audience but contain no verifiable activation, retention, or signup-conversion percentages; not used to set any target in this document.